

something like, "It's only \$100!" ask them why it's so important for them to take such a small sum away from you.

17. Keep as much of the communication in writing as possible. Oral agreements (and disagreements) simply don't offer enough proof.
18. Be respectful in all of your communication. You might want to say "You cheap, cheap bastard! I lived in this ratty @\$*\$ for two years and never complained about the @\$*\$ conditions!" but you always come off better if you are polite and well-mannered. If you do have to go to small claims court, judges will look askance at written proof of your rudeness.
19. If you do decide to take a landlord to small claims court, if only to fight what you see as injustice (and keep in mind that if you win, you might be able to get your court fees paid for), do let them know ahead of time. This might avoid the hassle of actually going to court. However, don't make empty threats. Be prepared to litigate if you threaten to do so.
20. If you don't get your money back, do make sure to publicize your experience. Be reasonable, but if you truly believe that you were screwed over, let other people know. Use a site

like CitySearch.com or Yelp.com to enter information about the property to warn other potential renters. Make sure that you don't exaggerate or do anything that could be construed as libel.

— **Andrea Karim**



How to Avoid 10 Costly DIY Mistakes

I love DIY. I'm completely awful at it, but as I'm thrifty I'd much rather do something myself than pay someone else three times as much to do it. But here's the rub: You can end up costing yourself more in the long run by doing it yourself. So, I scoured the web looking for the obvious and not-so-obvious mistakes DIY addicts make and compiled this list.

1. Cheap tools, no tools, the wrong tools

You can start a job thinking you have all the right equipment, but hammer-